

28% IN CONSERVATIVE CHENNAI ADMIT TO EXTRA MARITAL AFFAIRS

■ By Anjali Chhabria

Sagar, 32, married for eight years, seeks counselling as he has found his soul mate and realised his marriage was a mistake. His wife wants to work on the relationship and their six-year-old son suffers from insecurity. But he doesn't want to let go of his "love" who is his wife's best friend.

Sagar is not an oddity.

Infidelity is rising, and marriage seems to be its most fertile ground. Clearly, it's a male thing—31 per cent of men say they had extra marital affairs while only 6 per cent women admit to it. Monogamy is increasingly going out of fashion, not just in daily soaps but also in daily life. Research suggests there is a 30-50 per cent increase in the rate of cases of infidelity. But why? As a

practising psychiatrist, it is amazing how often this breach of trust occurs accidentally—a drinking session, a flirtatious colleague or sheer propinquity with friends. It is probably one of these reasons, or all in unison, that makes a person step out of the sanctity of a committed relationship.

Infidelity at times is the outcome of a problematic marriage and sometimes it

is the cause of such a marriage. Which comes first may be difficult to understand. The reasons are many: boredom, incompatibility, conflicts and sometimes children. At times, it has nothing to do with the quality of marriage, but with the spouse's personality. But perhaps the most dangerous reason is sexual addiction outside marriage—the desire to be with someone just for the thrill. Infidelity can be sexual or emotional and each individual has a different definition of cheating. Forty-seven per cent men feel emotional infidelity does not mean an extra marital affair. Many men also feel having a sexual relation outside the marriage is not infidelity. But for a woman, sexual or emotional infidelity is cheating (30 per cent). In fact, 35 per cent of men said they had an extra marital affair with their ex-girlfriends, closely followed by neighbours (29 per cent) and colleagues (24 per cent), which may explain their view about working women. Thirty-five per cent think working women are more sexually liberated.

Rahila, 30, says she had been happily married for four years. Then out of nowhere, she began feeling bored. She tried looking for answers. "All the information I received made me believe that my husband was the culprit. And I wanted to

Whom did you have an extra marital affair with?

		MALE	FEMALE
Ex-girlfriend/boyfriend	34	35	28
Neighbour	27	29	18
Colleague	23	24	19
Paid sex	18	21	4
One-night stand	14	15	5
Relative	12	13	9
Friend	11	12	7
Spouse's friend	11	12	11

All figures in per cent. Figures add up to more than 100 because of multiple choices.

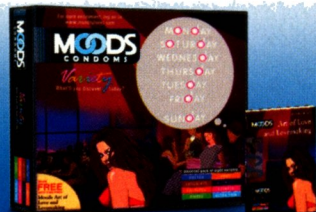
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CHOCOLATE

FRUIT

DOTTED

ALL NIGHT

ULTRA THIN

RIBBED

EXTRA LONG

SCENTED